

Editorial

Morphosyntactic mismatches in lexical categories

Deviations from the ideal one:one mapping between structure meaning are commonplace in language, but some deviations appear more striking than others. These tend to earn the label ‘mismatches’ in modern theoretical linguistics and they are rightly considered important. One specific type of mismatch is found when a word seems to behave in some respects as though it belonged to one category (say, in its morphological properties) and in other respects as though it belonged to a different category (say, in its syntactic properties). Words of this type are often said to instantiate ‘mixed categories’. In the past, however, the literature dealing with the kinds of mismatch we are interested in has tended to be somewhat restricted, concentrating on a relatively narrow dataset deriving from action nominalizations in relatively familiar languages. To be sure there are honourable exceptions to this trend (including many of the papers in the collection edited by Francis and Michaelis, 2003a). However, we believe that category ‘mixing’ is far less parochial than might appear from the theoretical literature. Moreover, we believe that careful study of various types of category mixing can throw important light on more well-behaved grammatical structures and categories. In other words, along with Francis and Michaelis (2003b), we think that morphosyntactic mismatches in general constitute a “crucible for linguistic theory”.

We present here three papers which look at mismatches and their implications for the analysis of specific languages and language groups and their implications for linguistic theory generally. All three papers arose out of a workshop (Arbeitsgruppe) organised by Wilhelm Geuder and Irene Rapp, which formed part of the 2002 meeting of the Deutsche Gesellschaft für Sprachwissenschaft (DGfS) held at the University of Mannheim. Each address empirical issues which are seldom discussed in the general literature and each can be said to argue for a ‘lexicalist’ approach to the respective problem, as opposed to an approach which appeals to phrasal affixation, syntactic word formation or other syntactically-oriented descriptive devices. In this respect each paper contributes to debate about the nature of lexical categories.

Iida and Sells look at the Japanese ‘manner of action’ deverbal nominalization in *-kata*. Complements to nouns so formed may retain certain properties of verb complements. Iida and Sells argue, nonetheless, that *-kata* suffixation applies to words, not phrases, and the mismatches are defined at a subphrasal level. They draw wide-ranging and interesting conclusions about the architecture of morphosyntax from these apparently recondite Japanese facts. Nikolaeva and Spencer both discuss a cinderella category, that of adjective. Nikolaeva looks at Tungusic ‘proprietives’, denominal adjectives with the meaning ‘having N’. These words straddle the boundary between adjective and noun and Nikolaeva argues that they can best be understood if categoriality doesn’t rely on a single definitional feature but depends on various parameters (syntactic, semantic and morphological). Spencer focusses on the negative form of Japanese

verbs. Morphologically, the negative paradigm is essentially identical to that of an adjective, yet, Spencer argues, these negative forms remain verbs in the syntax. He uses this to argue for the idea that we must distinguish between the morphological category of a lexeme and its syntactic category. In the case of Japanese verbs the morphological category depends on which cell of the verb paradigm we are talking about.

References

- Francis, E.J., Michaelis, L.A. (Eds.), 2003a. *Mismatch: Form-function Incongruity and the Architecture of Grammar*. CSLI, Stanford, CA.
- Francis, E.J., Michaelis, L.A., 2003b. *Mismatch: a crucible for linguistic theory*. In: Francis, E.J., Michaelis, L.A. (Eds.), *Mismatch: Form-function Incongruity and the Architecture of Grammar*. CSLI, Stanford, CA, pp. 1–30.

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28 July 2006

Available online 26 July 2007